

74% of millennials and 52% of baby boomers believe millionaires inherited all their wealth.

We'll dig into the research more in the next chapter, but what accounts for this huge gap between belief and reality? It's because of all the lies we hear that are intended to make us feel better about our own situations. Listen, if you feel stuck and you're not hitting your financial goals, I don't *want* anything or anyone to make you feel better about it. I want you to get fired up about *changing* it!

We also hear all these messages about how terrible rich people are. Wealth—and the pursuit of wealth—is somehow looked down upon, as though everyone striving to build wealth is doing something wrong. We see headlines that highlight what some rich, greedy jerk has done, and we get confused. We start to think that “rich” is the problem and give the “greedy jerk” part a pass. Why? If someone's a greedy jerk, it doesn't matter how much money they have. They aren't giving the wealthy a bad name; they're giving themselves a bad name! I don't want you to become a greedy jerk, but I do want you to become wealthy. You, like Bill Gates and Warren Buffet, can put your wealth to work for good causes. You can make this world—and your neighborhood—a better place for everyone. By building wealth and using it responsibly, you can fight back against the lies the world is telling people about the wealthy.

All of these things work together to create a distorted picture of what the typical American millionaire looks like. We've taken what we've seen in movies and in the news and turned those untruths and half-truths into several myths about millionaires. Then, we fall back on these myths as excuses for why we can't do it, won't do it, and shouldn't do it. The problem is, though, that a lot of people are doing it—and they don't look,